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Published by
Adrian Horton,Benjamin Lee
Estimated reading time
5 min
Added on
2026-10-29
Address
https://www.theguardian.com/culture/2026/oct/29/patrick-stewart-dead

Patrick Stewart, Star Trek actor and acclaimed thespian, dies aged 86

Patrick Stewart, the acclaimed British stage and screen actor renowned for both Shakespeare and sci-fi, has died. He was 86.

The Star Trek: the Next Generation and X-Men star died on Wednesday at his home in Los Angeles after "a brief and poignant journey with Alzheimer's disease and Lewy body dementia", said Kelly Bush Novak, his longtime spokesperson, to the Hollywood Reporter.

"He has been held in the warm embrace of family and friends, surrounded by live music, prayer, tears, laughter and the kind of profound emotion that only he could inspire after a lifetime of devotion to us all," she wrote. "We will forever cherish the peaceful ease and reflection on his face, an enduring reminder of his invincible grace."

With his authoritative baritone voice and commanding visage, Stewart was already a staple of the British stage by the late 1980s when, at 47, he was cast as a graying Capt Jean-Luc Picard in Star Trek: the Next Generation, the first live-action spin-off of the groundbreaking 1960s TV series. Over seven seasons onboard the Starship Enterprise, Stewart's even-keeled performance and steely directives – "engage!" and "make it so" – turned him into a global star.

Stewart reprised his role in four feature film spin-offs – Star Trek Generations (1994), Star Trek: First Contact (1996), Star Trek: Insurrection (1998) and Star Trek: Nemesis (2002) – as well as the TV series Star Trek: Picard, which ran from 2020 until 2023.

Fellow Star Trek actor William Shatner paid tribute on social media. "From the stage to the bridge of the Enterprise, he brought intelligence, grace, and a deep sense of humanity to everything he did," he wrote. "Captain Picard stood for the best of us, and so did the man who played him. I was filled with affection and admiration for him and his work."

George Takei, who played Hikaru Sulu in the original series, also wrote about Stewart on Bluesky. "He inspired a whole next generation of star-gazers who looked longingly ahead to a brighter future for all humanity," he posted. "Our hearts are heavy, indeed. Rest in the heavens, Captain."

His other most well-known role was playing Prof Charles Xavier in the X-Men series. The actor had found work hard to obtain after feeling typecast as a result of his Star Trek role but had been intrigued by working with director Bryan Singer for 2000's X-Men.

He went on to play the role in seven films and will be seen reprising the role in this December's Avengers: Doomsday.

His X-Men co-star Hugh Jackman shared the following on Instagram today: "We lost one of the greats of stage and screen today. And, in my book, a tremendous friend and man. I learned so much from him. I will miss you, Patrick Stewart, all of my days."

Marvel chief Kevin Feige has paid tribute in a statement calling him "brilliant, charming, warm, generous, with a quiet strength and gravitas". He added: "Away from the cameras, he was even more remarkable, with a wonderfully sharp sense of humor. It was a true privilege to know him and to work with him. His legacy lives on not only in decades of extraordinary work, but in the many, many people he mentored. He will be deeply missed."

His other film roles included the gay comedy Jeffrey, romantic thriller Conspiracy Theory, violent horror Green Room and voice roles in Ted, Gnomeo & Juliet and, most recently, The Sheep Detectives.

Born on 13 July 1940 in the small industrial village of Mirfield, England, Stewart was the youngest of three sons born to Alfred Stewart, a British military veteran turned semiskilled laborer, and Gladys Stewart, a weaver at a textile factory. His childhood, in a small house with no running hot water, was marred by alcoholism and domestic violence, a situation he later described, in an article for the Guardian from 2009, as "barely tolerable".

He found respite in acting, first in school – he was 12 when an English teacher assigned him the part of Shylock in Shakespeare's The Merchant of Venice – and then local drama groups. "I managed to find my own refuge in acting," he wrote. "The stage was a far safer place for me than anything I had to live through at home – it offered escape. I could be someone else, in another place, in another time."

After graduating from secondary school at 15, he worked as a local reporter and furniture salesman before a local arts council provided the funding to attend the prestigious Bristol Old Vic Theater School, where he enrolled in 1957, at 17. Having shed his Yorkshire accent, he took his first professional theater role two years later, and in 1966 joined the Royal Shakespeare Company. During his 16 years with the company, Stewart developed a reputation as one of the finest thespians of his era and a representative of Shakespeare to new audiences; it was while conducting master classes on Shakespeare in LA, at the invitation of a friend, that he first caught the eye of a TV casting director for Star Trek.

Stewart made his Broadway debut in 1971 in Peter Brook's A Midsummer Night's Dream, and appeared again 20 years later in a solo production of A Christmas Carol. The holiday season show, which he revived in 1992, 1994 and 2001, received a Drama Desk award.

Over the course of his career, Stewart embodied many of Shakespeare's signature roles, including Macbeth, Othello, Prospero, Shylock and Mark Antony. He was the recipient of two Laurence Olivier awards – in 1979, for Antony and Cleopatra, and in 2009 for Hamlet – as well as a Grammy in 1996 for a spoken word children's album Prokofiev: Peter and the Wolf. He was also nominated for a Tony and four Emmys.

His final major stage role was in 2016, when he appeared as Hirst in Harold Pinter's No Man's Land at London's Wyndham Theatre. In 2023, he released his memoir called Making It So.

Stewart was a vocal fan of Huddersfield Town FC since he was a child and was seen cheering them on most recently in 2024. In a Facebook post from the official team, he was called "a titan of his craft and a legend and hero to millions worldwide".

Stewart was married three times: to theater choreographer Sheila Falconer, from 1966 until 1990 and with whom he had two children, fellow actors Daniel and Sophie; to Star Trek producer Wendy Neuss from 2000 until 2003; and to jazz musician Sunny Ozell from 2013 until his death. His friend and occasional collaborator Ian McKellen, with whom Stewart starred in two Broadway productions in 2013, officiated his final wedding after a rehearsal.

"I think I've been in denial about my life for a very long time," he said to the Guardian in a 2023 interview. "I never really took on board how successful I had become. Even today I sometimes think, 'You're a lucky son of a bitch, Patrick,' when something unexpected or good happens to me."

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